

THE COMPLETE SEO PLAYBOOK

20 phases to rank any business website
From technical SEO to AI/LLM optimization

A reusable checklist for any business website
Traditional SEO + Local SEO + AI/LLM SEO

2026 EDITION

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PHASE 1 - Initial Audit

Day-0 work: understand the competitive landscape before writing a single line of code.

Checklist

- * Identify top 1-3 competitors ranking for target keywords
- * Compare competitors' meta titles/descriptions side-by-side with yours
- * Note claim density (adjectives like 'best', 'trusted', 'leading')
- * Check competitor's domain age, GBP review count, backlinks via Ahrefs free checker
- * Document the gap: brand-led title vs claim-led title
- * Check Google Search Console for existing penalties, spam issues, deindexing
- * Verify canonical domain (.in vs .com vs .co.in) - pick one, redirect rest

PHASE 2 - Canonical NAP & Identity Setup

NAP = Name, Address, Phone. Inconsistency across the web actively hurts rankings.

Lock these values in a single master CSV/Notion

- * Business Name (exact text used everywhere)
- * Address (street, city, state, postal, country)
- * Phone (one primary, optional WhatsApp/secondary)
- * Email (one company-owned, never personal)
- * Domain (decide .in vs .com once)
- * Business Hours
- * Geo Coordinates
- * Government License Number (if regulated industry)
- * Audit codebase for any old/wrong NAP variations and fix all

PHASE 3 - Technical SEO Foundation

Sitemap & robots

- * Verify sitemap.xml exists and lists every important page
- * Set priority (homepage = 1.0, hub pages = 0.9, leaf pages = 0.7)
- * Set changeFrequency realistically (homepage weekly, leaf pages monthly)
- * Verify robots.txt doesn't accidentally block crawlers

Per-page setup

- * Set metaDataBase in root layout
- * Set canonical URL on every page (alternates: { canonical: '/path' })
- * Use title: { absolute: '...' } to bypass template appending where needed

Schema.org JSON-LD on layout

- * LocalBusiness + Organization + WebSite types
- * aggregateRating (if you have real reviews)
- * OpeningHoursSpecification (if local business)
- * geo with lat/long
- * areaServed listing all cities/countries served
- * priceRange field
- * sameAs array with social profile URLs

PHASE 4 - Meta Title & Description Rewrites

Title rules

- * Lead with claim word, not brand: 'Best X in [Location]' not 'BrandName | services'
- * Keep under 60 characters (truncation point)
- * Use title: { absolute: '...' } when you don't want template appending

Description rules

- * Keep under 158 characters
- * Front-load keywords in first 80 chars
- * Stack 3 service categories (e.g., 'travel agent, immigration office, recruitment')
- * Include proof points (license number, years, rating)
- * Test how Google renders: search site:yourdomain.com after deploy

PHASE 5 - On-Page H1/Body Match

If meta description doesn't match H1/intro, Google rewrites your snippet. Fix the on-page so the snippet sticks.

Checklist

- * H1 must echo the title's claim word ('Best ...' or '#1 ...')
- * Add sub-headline below H1 absorbing additional keywords
- * First paragraph repeats key claims (license, years, geography)
- * Use semantic HTML (h1 once, h2 for sections, h3 for sub-sections)
- * Bold key claim phrases in body copy

PHASE 6 - State/Region-Level Landing Page

Checklist

- * Build a state-level page (e.g., /punjab) not just city pages
- * Target state-level queries ('best X in [State]')
- * Include 'Cities We Serve' section linking to each city page
- * LocalBusiness JSON-LD with areaServed listing all cities
- * State-level testimonials covering multiple cities
- * State-level FAQs different from city FAQs
- * Set sitemap priority HIGHER than individual city pages (0.95 vs 0.9)

PHASE 7 - Per-City Pages

Most common SEO mistake

Copy-pasting city pages with just the city name swapped. Google flags this as duplicate content and only ranks one. Each city page must have UNIQUE content blocks.

Each city page needs

- * 3 unique testimonials (different names, neighborhoods, jobs)
- * 6 trust reasons with LOCAL specifics (distance, bus fare, landmarks)
- * 3+ city-specific FAQs ('How do I reach you from [City]?')
- * Local industry/worker profile mention
- * LocalBusiness JSON-LD per city with that city's geo data

PHASE 8 - Service & Visa (Sub-Page) Pages

Each must have **UNIQUE** country/service-specific content

- * Country-specific terminology ('Voivode office' Poland, 'Iqama' Saudi)
- * Country-specific salary ranges, timelines, permit types
- * Country-specific FAQs
- * Add Service schema with provider reference

PHASE 9 - Internal Linking Architecture

Audit + fix

- * Identify orphaned pages (0 inbound links) and fix
- * Footer: every important page must be in footer at least once
- * Navbar: 7-9 top links covering main user journeys
- * Don't over-link to /contactus - rebalance equity
- * Link to state-level page from every city page

Build shared cluster components for reuse

- * CityCluster - sibling cities cross-link from each city
- * RelatedVisas - visa pages cross-link within Europe/Gulf groups
- * RelatedServices - services cross-link to relevant visas
- * Each cluster component takes currentSlug prop to exclude self

PHASE 10 - Duplicate Content Detection & Fix

Detection

- * Manually diff similar pages side-by-side - count % shared text
- * Google's duplicate threshold ~ 50%+ shared content flags issue
- * Check GSC -> Pages -> 'Duplicate, Google chose different canonical' report

Fix

- * Rewrite testimonials per city - different names, neighborhoods, stories
- * Rewrite trust reasons per city with local specifics
- * Rewrite FAQs per city with locality-specific questions
- * Shared visual components (testimonials marquee, Google reviews) - Google treats as chrome, OK to duplicate

PHASE 11 - Trust & E-E-A-T Signals

E-E-A-T = Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness. Critical post-2024 Google update.

Schema additions

- * Add Person schema for founder/owner
- * Include founder's description, knowsAbout, jobTitle
- * Add EducationalOccupationalCredential for licenses/certifications
- * Add affiliation for industry memberships

Visible on site

- * Display license numbers visibly
- * Display founding year and years-in-business
- * Real aggregateRating tied to verifiable source
- * Team photos, office photos, certificates
- * Author byline on blog posts and guides

PHASE 12 - Cornerstone Content (Long-form Guides)

Build 3-5 deep guide pages (1500+ words each)

- * Topics: 'How to choose X', country comparisons, process step-by-step
- * Each guide gets Article schema with author + publisher
- * Process guides also get HowTo schema (with step, totalTime, supply)
- * All guides get embedded FAQPage schema (8-10 Q&As each)
- * Include real numbers (salary ranges, timelines, costs)
- * Include tables (Google likes structured data)
- * Link to authoritative sources (.gov sites, official portals)
- * Link from guides to your service/visa pages
- * Build a /guides hub page with CollectionPage schema

PHASE 13 - AI / LLM SEO (Answer Engine Optimization)

New in 2025-2026

Modern users research via ChatGPT, Perplexity, Claude, Gemini. If your brand isn't cited there, you're invisible at the research stage. AEO is the new SEO.

Foundational

- * Create public/llms.txt - table of contents + authoritative facts for AI crawlers
- * Include: business identity, services, factual answers to common Qs, key landing pages
- * Structure content as Q&A format (LLMs prefer this for extraction)
- * Use concrete numbers, not vague ranges
- * Cite authoritative sources visibly (links to .gov)
- * Heavy use of FAQPage schema across pages

External signals (LLMs scrape these)

- * Get mentioned on Reddit with detailed answers
- * Get mentioned on Quora with deep responses
- * Get mentioned in regional press / industry blogs (LLM training data)
- * Test by asking ChatGPT/Perplexity - does your brand surface?

PHASE 14 - Google Business Profile (Local SEO)

Higher ROI than website SEO for local businesses

GBP optimization moves the map pack faster than any other SEO work. Treat as 1-week sprint, not afterthought.

Setup

- * Claim/verify GBP at business.google.com
- * Set primary + 4 additional categories
- * Match address exactly to website schema
- * Upload 20+ photos: exterior, interior, team, certificates, success stories
- * Geo-tag photos before uploading
- * Set service area (cities + radius)
- * Write 750-char description with keywords (claim-led)
- * Add all services with descriptions
- * Enable Messaging with auto-reply
- * Seed 5-10 Q&As yourself (allowed)

Reviews & engagement

- * Generate review-request short link
- * WhatsApp last 50 customers (varied messages, spread over 2 weeks)
- * Target 4.5+ rating with 50+ reviews minimum
- * Reply to every review within 24 hours
- * Post 1-2 GBP updates per week (job openings, success stories, news)
- * Mark special hours (holidays, festivals)

PHASE 15 - Backlinks Strategy

Tier 1 - Free directories

- * JustDial, Sulekha, IndiaMart, TradeIndia, AskLaila, Cylex, HotFrog, Yellow Pages India
- * Submit exact NAP from master data - don't vary

Tier 1 - Government (highest authority)

- * Verify business listed on industry regulator's public site (.gov.in)
- * MSME / Udyam registration (India)
- * Industry portal listings (NCS, GeM if applicable)

Tier 2 - Social profile backlinks

- * YouTube channel description -> site URL
- * Each YouTube video description -> site URL
- * Instagram bio -> site URL
- * Facebook About -> website field
- * LinkedIn Company Page -> website

Tier 2 - Press releases (5-15 backlinks per release)

- * Write one 350-500 word press release with milestone angle
- * Submit to: PRLog, IndianPRWire, BusinessWire, NewKerala, DailyHunt, OpenPR
- * Some free, some Rs.500-5000 paid

Tier 2 - Local press pitches

- * One pitch per week to regional outlets
- * Tribune, Hindustan Times regional, Punjab Kesari, regional language papers
- * Angle: milestones, success stories, industry trends

Tier 3 - Content compounding

- * Quora: 2 answers per week to relevant questions
- * Reddit: 1 helpful comment per week (build karma first, link sparingly)
- * YouTube: 1 short video per week, link to site in description
- * Customer-side: ask placed customers to LinkedIn-post and tag your business

AVOID (toxic backlinks)

Fiverr backlink packages, Private Blog Networks (PBNs), forum signature spam, comment spam, paid guest posts on unrelated blogs, article spinning sites. These trigger Google penalties.

PHASE 16 - Sitemap Submission & Re-Indexing

Checklist

- * Submit sitemap.xml in GSC -> Sitemaps
- * For any new page or major content change, use GSC -> URL Inspection -> 'Request Indexing'
- * Rate limit: ~10/day, spread over multiple days for big batches
- * Prioritize: homepage > new pages > pages with new sections > pages with meta changes
- * Monitor GSC Pages report 7-14 days later for indexing status

PHASE 17 - Tracking & Iteration

Tools to set up (all free)

- * Google Search Console - backlinks + indexing
- * Google Analytics (or PostHog)
- * Ahrefs Backlink Checker (free) - monthly
- * Moz Link Explorer (free) - monthly
- * Whitespark Local Rank Tracker - bi-weekly local map ranking
- * Ubersuggest - keyword trends

Track weekly

- * New backlinks (GSC Links report)
- * New GBP reviews
- * New impressions for target keywords (GSC Performance)
- * Click-through rate (CTR) on snippets - low CTR = bad title/description

Track monthly

- * Domain Rating / Authority change
- * Total indexed pages
- * Top 10 ranking keywords
- * Direct vs organic traffic split
- * GBP profile views, direction requests, calls

PHASE 18 - Content Cadence (Ongoing)

Task	Frequency
GBP post	2x per week
New Quora answer	2x per week
Reddit helpful comment	1x per week
New YouTube video	1x per week
Reply to all reviews	Daily check
New blog post / guide	1x per month
Press release	1x per quarter
Local press pitch	1x per week
Update GBP photos	3-5 new per week
New backlink building	5+ per week

PHASE 19 - Modern Customer Journey Coverage

Most businesses optimize only Decision-stage. Aim for all 5 stages.

Stage	Channels	What to build
Discovery	Instagram, TikTok, YouTube Shorts	Short-form video, social posting cadence
Research	ChatGPT, Perplexity, Reddit, Quora	Long-form guides, FAQ pages, llms.txt, Quora/Reddit presence
Decision	Google search	
Validation	YouTube reviews, Trustpilot, Google	Multi-platform reviews, video testimonials
Purchase	WhatsApp, contact form, walk-in	Smooth conversion path, multiple contact options

PHASE 20 - Pre-Launch Checklist (Final)

Verify before going live

- * All pages have title + description + canonical
- * All pages have unique H1
- * All schemas validate at validator.schema.org or Google Rich Results Test
- * No duplicate content >50% between similar pages
- * Sitemap auto-generates with all current pages
- * robots.txt allows Googlebot
- * llms.txt published at root
- * 404 page exists and looks intentional
- * HTTPS enforced site-wide
- * Mobile responsive (Google mobile-first indexing)
- * Page load < 3 seconds (Core Web Vitals)
- * All images have alt text
- * All <a> links have descriptive text (not 'click here')
- * All external links to authoritative sources, not spammy
- * GSC + Analytics installed and reporting
- * GBP claimed and complete
- * At least 25 inbound backlinks before launch
- * At least 20 Google reviews before launch

PHASE X - What NOT to do (common mistakes)

Avoid all of these:

- * Don't stuff keywords unnaturally in body copy
- * Don't buy backlinks
- * Don't copy-paste content between city/service pages
- * Don't use brand-led titles ('BrandName | Services')
- * Don't ignore mobile
- * Don't ignore page speed
- * Don't ignore E-E-A-T (author, credentials, license)
- * Don't use the same H1 on multiple pages
- * Don't leave alt text empty on important images
- * Don't forget canonical tags (causes self-cannibalization)
- * Don't have orphan pages (0 inbound links)
- * Don't ignore GBP - it drives more local traffic than SEO
- * Don't optimize only for Google - modern users also search ChatGPT, Reddit, YouTube
- * Don't ignore Trustpilot, Glassdoor, AmbitionBox if relevant
- * Don't skip llms.txt - it's 2026 table stakes
- * Don't write press releases as ads (won't get published)
- * Don't ignore review responses - Google scores response rate
- * Don't use shortened/redirected URLs in backlinks (loses equity)
- * Don't change URL structure post-launch without 301 redirects
- * Don't have inconsistent NAP across the web

PHASE Y - Deliverable files (reference)

Recommended artefacts to produce for any complete SEO project. Use as a templates checklist.

File	Purpose
citation-tracker.csv	Master NAP data + GBP checklist + 50+ directory listings
backlinks-action-plan.csv	Press, content, customer-side strategies, weekly schedule
seo-tracker.xlsx	Merged multi-tab workbook for Google Sheets
public/lms.txt	AI crawler authority file (business facts, FAQs, key pages)
sitemap.xml / sitemap.ts	Dynamic sitemap with priority + changeFrequency
Root layout schema	Site-wide LocalBusiness + Organization + WebSite JSON-LD
State/region landing page	Region-level page above city pages
Per-city pages	Unique content per city (testimonials, trust, FAQs)
Cornerstone guides hub	3-5 long-form guides with Article + HowTo + FAQ schema
Cluster components	Shared internal-linking blocks (CityCluster, RelatedVisas, etc.)

Work through phases 1-20 in order. Skip nothing - every phase compounds with the others. Reusable across any business website, in any industry, in any geography.